The Mihai Eminescu Trust

NEWSLETTER 2007

The most important event of the year was the completion of the Apafi Manor House, which left a profound sense of achievement stemming from four years of hard work culminating in the beautiful building that has emerged. Our heartfelt thanks go to Dr Packard for backing us to see through this very large and difficult restoration project, as well as to our chief architect, Jan Hülsemann, and our leading craftsman, Ernst Linzing. In May we held a party for the builders, stonemasons, stucco and lime mortar craftsmen, carpenters, fresco painters, gardeners, brick and tile makers, sheep's wool insulators, metalworkers, locksmiths and others who collaborated on the building - Hungarians, Romanians, Saxons, Roma, Germans and British.

At the official opening and consecration in October, the afternoon began with a brief service in Malancrav Lutheran church, officiated by Lutheran, Romanian Orthodox and Hungarian Catholic priests. After prayers and hymns, Caroline Fernolend, Romanian director of the Trust, spoke to the 200-strong congregation about the role the villagers had played in the rebuilding of the Manor, under the guidance of Jan Hülsemann. She mentioned with pride the international recognition given to the project, highlighted by the coveted Europa Nostra first prize.



Later, in the library, Corina Raducanu played Scarlatti on the restored Samuel Maetz clavichord and Oana Voicu, the renowned violinist from Bucharest, played Romanian dances by Bartok. In the garden, Andrea Rost performed Saxon dances with her group, while Jakob Kripp offered his elegant Prince Stirbey wines from the famous Dragasani estate of his grandfather-in-law. We thank them all.

The house is now available for private letting or small cultural events and conferences. It sleeps 9, contains a library specialising in East European history, and has two housekeepers to attend to visitors' every need.



Overshadowed by the Apafi Manor but scarcely less important was the conversion in July of the historic Tower House in the Sighisoara citadel – now the Trust's office but also able to accommodate two guests. The Leather Coat Makers' Tower, to which the house is attached, is to be restored as a demonstration, training and documentary centre for our restoration work.

Another significant opening took place in May - the small Saxon church in Floresti, fully repaired and restored by the MET with support from Horizon Foundation. The local community is now hoping to raise money to organise a small museum and exhibition place inside the deconsecrated church and bring the original altar back from Sighisoara.

THE WHOLE VILLAGE PROJECT AND TRAINING PROGRAMME IN THE SAXON VILLAGES

In the Viscri area – the villages of Bunesti, Cloasterf, Crit, Mesendorf, Saschiz and Viscri - we completed 49 restoration projects. Work continued on the fortified walls of the Bunesti church, while in Crit we started a project aimed at reinstating traditional wooden shutters. The wood-burning kiln built last year in Viscri is now providing bricks and tiles for the area.

In the Malancrav area, apart from the Manor, we completed 21 other projects. In Malancrav itself, 15 house exteriors were restored, including the old Orthodox school and the Catholic parish house. Our local team also repaired the pavements with traditional stones. In Floresti we worked on a large project on the Orthodox Church, repairing the roof, plastering and painting the exterior and rebuilding a stone and wood fence. We also started working in the

village of Cris, where the romantic Bethlen castle is situated. In Noul Sasesc we arrested the degradation of the Greek-Catholic church, in the hope of raising further funds to restore this wonderful monument.

We also prepared for work in Drauseni and on the church in Axente Sever and, with the support of the EU's Culture 2000 programme, we completed two restoration projects in Hosman and one in Apold, as well as the Tower House and the facade of 2 Scolii Street in Sighisoara. In all, we employed more than 56 local conservation craftsmen and architects on these projects.



Building restored in Malancrav



Houses restored in Viscri

Throughout the year we held village training seminars on the principles and techniques of historic building conservation.
Workshops and presentations were given by Caroline Fernolend and Jan Hülsemann in Richis, Malancrav, Mosna, Cata, Nemsa, Bunesti, Drauseni, Alma Vii, Floresti and Viscri. Caroline Fernolend also spoke to specialists and students from Rosia Montana, Grosii Tiblesului and Tirgu Jiu. We thank Ian Pritchett and Marianne Suhr, SPAB conservation experts from Britain, for their presentations about the work of the MET, as well as architects Dorin Boila, Robert Farczadi, Stefan Balici and Virgil Apostol from Romania.



Traditional buildings seminar, May 2007

Architects for Aid (A4A) sent nine architects to Transylvania in February. The team were deployed in seven villages to make studies of endangered houses, saving the Trust weeks of work in preparing documentation for the year ahead. On their second visit A4A held workshops on community consultation and involvement in heritage conservation projects.

The Trust, in partnership with GTZ, organised a two-day seminar in Sighisoara with local authorities from the Saxon villages of Transylvania. The event, attended by 46 people, aimed to raise awareness of the importance of eco-friendly infrastructure in areas with special cultural heritage value. Sanitation was a key issue, debated with experts from the Romanian Ministry of Environment and Water Management, the Ministry of Health and UNDP Romania, as well as specialists from Germany, the Netherlands and Finland. The MET's patron, HRH The Prince of Wales, has raised significant funds to introduce ecological sanitation in Viscri.

EU LEONARDO PROGRAMME

The Trust is participating in the Leonardo da Vinci programme, which funds overseas work placements with the object of improving the provision of vocational education and training across Europe. Under the leadership of Colin Richards (Conservation Officer for South Shropshire), a party of 12 young professional building workers and a group of expert craftsmen travelled from the UK to join a team of their Romanian counterparts in Viscri. During the 10-day period of the workshops a number of projects were completed. The British team gained much from the experience both as individuals learning and sharing in the life of the village and also from such tasks as sourcing and selecting timber from the forests and converting it for use by their own hands using

ancient tools such as the side axe and adze. The visit proved a transforming experience for the younger members of the group, who absorbed the art of working as part of a team. On the plane back to England, a number of them described it to Colin Richards as the best experience of their lives.

RAILWAY

The MET's campaign to restore the closed line of the Sibiu-Agnita narrow-gauge railway has now resulted in the railway being registered as a national monument and the threat of it being dismantled has been averted. Together with the New Europe Railway Heritage Trust and the Hartibaci Valley Association, and with the valuable support of UK railway expert Bill Parker, we have come closer to setting up a consortium for the repair and reopening of this historic line.

PUBLIC PRESENTATIONS

London, March 21st. Jessica Douglas-Home gave a presentation on the MET, its goals and achievements, the Whole Village Project and the Saxon villages of Transylvania to more than 40 members and guests of the Luxembourg Society.

Bucharest, March 29th. Luminita Holban, our London director, gave a presentation at the Romexpo exhibition centre about the Whole Village Project and the revitalisation of the Saxon villages through training and sustainable tourism.

Bucharest, April 19th. Caroline Fernolend, Stefan Balici and Jan Hülseman gave presentations at the Archaeology Institute of the Romanian Academy about Gabriel Lambescu and his work for the MET. This was followed on April 21st by a talk and exhibition on Rosia Montana and the Saxon villages of Transylvania as "poles of cultural heritage conservation".

London, May 8th. With the support of the Romanian Cultural Institute, we held an event of lectures, film projections, visual exhibition, dance and music aimed at raising awareness of the Whole Village Project and the beauty and plight of the Saxon villages of Transylvania.

Viscri, May 27th. Caroline Fernolend gave a celebration party for all those who have helped her village over the last 10 years. The day began with a service in the beautiful church and festivities continued throughout the day with Romanian, Hungarian and Saxon singing, dancing and music late into the night.

Stockholm, June 8th. At the Europa Nostra Award ceremony held in Stockholm's Nobel Prize Hall, in the presence of the King and Queen of Sweden, HRH Princess Madeleine (Patron of Europa Nostra) and Jan Figel (EU Culture Commissioner), the MET Chairman received on behalf of the Trust this year's top award for Dedicated Service to Conservation. The citation noted that "... the Trust has done more than any other organisation for the preservation of the Saxon heritage of Transylvania". (In October, Caroline Fernolend received the same award from Hermann Fabini, local representative of Europa Nostra, at a ceremony in Malancrav, attended by distinguished Romanian cultural and political personalities).



The Tower House in Sighisoara

Sibiu, August 20th. Caroline Fernolend spoke about the MET at the Deutsche Bundestiftung Umwelt.

Luxembourg, September 20th. With the support of the Romanian Cultural Institute, the MET and the Romanian Embassy hosted a three-hour symposium on the Saxon villages of Transylvania. Speakers included Luminita Holban and delegates from the University of Architecture, Bucharest, the Council of Europe and the Medias Local Action Group. The event coincided with two photographic exhibitions: "Saxon Villages: Memory, Renewal and Change"' by Gabriel Lambescu, opened by Ambassador Vlad Alexandrescu, and "Fortified Churches of Transylvania" by Robert Stollberg and Thomas Schulz.

Vienna, September 29th. Caroline Fernolend gave a presentation to the Trustees and patrons of the Horizon Foundation.

Toulouse, October 8th – 10th. Caroline Fernolend gave a paper "Atelier 14. La mediation culturelle dans la production de projets" to an audience of 850 at a congress organized by the Agence d' Urbanisme et d' Amenagement du Teritoire.

Bethune, October 11th. Caroline Fernolend also gave a presentation at the Artoiscomme.

Sibiu, October 16th. Jan Hülsemann spoke about the work of the MET with GTZ under their new project "Leistelle Kirchenburgen".

Miclosoara, November 8th. Luminita Holban took part in the Transylvania Authentica two-day workshop organised by The Prince of Wales and the Foundation for Partnership for the purpose of setting up a Transylvanian brand of traditional products, which would promote authentic, sustainable small businesses from the area.

London, November 28th. At a ceremony held at the Romanian Cultural Institute in the presence of 150 invited guests, the Ambassador, Raduta Matache, on behalf of the Romanian President, presented MET Chairman Jessica Douglas-Home with a distinguished National Order, citing her work before the fall of communism and her "... activity in promoting and developing the Romanian cultural patrimony". Mr Ion Caramitru, president of UNITER, and Mr Jonathan Eyal, director of studies at RUSI, spoke of her contribution to freedom, democracy and tradition. In reply, the Chairman paid tribute to those who had helped the Trust succeed.

BBC TV's Countryfile visited the Transylvanian villages in March. The following month their hour-long programme, broadcast worldwide to an audience of several million, featured the MET extensively. It also reviewed the impact in rural areas of Romania's accession to the EU.

PUBLICATIONS

With help from the EU's Culture 2000 programme, we published Gabriel Lambescu's lime guide, an essential tool for craftsmen working with lime mortar, plaster and lime wash. We also produced five leaflets with repair and conservation advice for facades, roofs, windows and shutters, barns and paving.

Our striking 2001 in-depth study "The Saxon Villages of Transylvania, A Future for the Mediaeval Landscape" by Kim Wilkie, originally commissioned for us by HRH The Prince of Wales, has been updated and reprinted, with assistance from the Romanian Cultural Institute's Cantemir programme.

THE BREITE PLATEAU

Early in the year the MET and the Sighisoara Local Council submitted their plan for the Breite ancient oak reserve. After twelve months' research and wide public consultation, our team – led by local biologists Cosmin Ioan Moga and Tibi Hartel – assembled a 100-page document comprising a detailed geographical, biological, historical and cultural description of Breite, an evaluation of existing and future threats, and a set of proposed management measures. New protection rules were approved, explaining which activities are permitted inside the protected area. On receiving custody of the reserve, the MET employed two full-time guards to patrol the plateau and inform visitors about the regulations. Since then, we have not had any severe cases of tree vandalism, although poaching and illegal woodcutting still occur in the surrounding forests.



The Breite wood-pasture

Last autumn the MET and the Sighisoara Forestry Office collected 10,000 acorns from Breite and planted them in the local nursery. Some 5,000 saplings have come out and will be re-planted on Breite or made available for purchase.

Local workers cleared the encroaching hornbeam saplings – an urgent measure for the preservation of the wood-pasture habitat created by Saxons in the Middle Ages, without which the surrounding forest would suffocate the old oaks. This year 14 hectares have been cleared, using manual mowers.

One of the MET's obligations as custodian is to gather, improve and enrich existing scientific data about the reserve. The results have been disseminated in academic circles at national and international conferences, including the World Congress of the International Association of Landscape Ecology. We thank all those who have adopted oaks and the experts who generously offered their knowledge and advice free of charge, especially George Peterken, Alexandru Ioan Toth, Bill Parker and Owen Mountford. The Breite Newsletter on our website contains detailed information about the plateau.

OTHER NATURE PROJECTS

The Romanian Government has approved two Natura 2000 protected areas, with financial and research contributions from the MET, in the area of Sighisoara and the Saxon villages. It is an important

step towards ensuring the conservation of this area's unique landscape and biodiversity.
The MET has obtained the agreement of the Bunesti local council and the Brasov county council for the establishment of Bunesti Natural Park, IUCN protected area category V. Their support is crucial in persuading the Government to approve the park.

LEADER PROGRAMME

MET initiated a Local Action Group (LAG) for village communities in Saxon Transylvania to benefit from EU funds through the Leader Programme for rural development. Initially, the proposed area was larger, including the town of Sighisoara and some 20 surrounding communes, but subsequently the group broke into two separate initiatives. We now have 33 founding members (10 local councils, 8 private companies, 5 NGOs, 3 schools and 7 individuals) from an area of 800 sq km and 56,000 inhabitants.
The first general assembly took place on the 15th of June, in Nemsa, where members and guest experts made presentations about the assets and opportunities presented by their region.
Alongside 75 participants, there was also a talk by Mrs Marja Kares-Oksman, manager of Pyhajarvi Lake District Development LAG from Finland, and Jan Hülsemann described the principles of village and building conservation.
In September, Luminita Holban met representatives of four LAGs from Luxembourg and the head of the Luxembourg rural development programme, Ms Francoise Bonert. The same month, the LAG acquired legal status, when the Medias Court approved its establishment as a non-profit association.

ORCHARD

This year's exceptional crop enabled us to produce more than 30,000 litres of organic apple juice while offering seasonal employment to the local community totalling more than 70 man-months.

GUESTHOUSES

We have had a good year for bookings. Many people have written afterwards of the wonderful experiences of village life in Viscri, Malancrav, Crit and Biertan. Now we have one more guesthouse to offer in Floresti, which sleeps two people. For all bookings please telephone: 0207 603 1113.

SMALL GRANTS

The MET helped a potter set up a small ceramics shop and atelier in the Sighisoara citadel, across the street from the Tower House.
We gave a grant to the Sighisoara Schools' Club for their national summer environmental camp, attended by around 60 children, which included a trip on Breite and several talks by local and visiting students on the value of the reserve.
A small donation helped fund local biologist Tibi Hartel's study on amphibians' mortality rate on public roads in the Sighisoara area.
We sponsored the transport of the Haltrich high school team from Sighisoara to Targu Mures for the inter-school biology contest.
The Trust donated office and computer equipment to the newly-established office of the Podisul Mediasului LAG, based in Mosna.
In Rosia Montana, we gave a grant to the "Architecture, Restoration, Archaeology" Association for emergency interventions on the Unitarian priest house and the Reformed priest house.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Our work owes everything to the generosity of our donors, especially the Packard Humanities Institute and the Horizon Foundation, but also the Headley Foundation, Lord Leach, Lord Rothschild, Michael Heathcoat Amory, Lazards, the Viscountess Boyd Trust and the EU's Culture 2000 programme. We thank HRH the Prince of Wales for raising money to install a sewage system in Viscri. Many of our large projects have come to fruition during 2007, and we hope that our donors are proud of their investment in the Trust.
We owe a great debt of gratitude to David Mlinaric for his help on the Apafi Manor, to Catherine Fitzgerald for her work on the Manor garden, and to Ilinca Bossy for her donation of books, pictures and furniture for the interior. Vanessa Williams Ellis and Richard Eeles, with the help of Bridget Guzner and Stephen Davies, designed the configuration of books in the library.
In the villages where we operate, our work has been transformed by the commitment of Colin Richards and his exceptional Shropshire team to an ongoing building programme.
We would like to thank Horia Patapievici, the President of the Romanian Cultural Institute, for the 200 books for the Apafi manor library, and Ana Blandiana for her books from the Civic Academy.

OTHER INFORMATION

The achievements of the Trust (registered charity no 1107300, www.mihaieminescutrust.org) are only made possible by your donations. Please send any gift possible to our office: The Mihai Eminescu Trust, 63 Hillgate Place, London W8 7SS, where books, brochures and information about all our activities are available.

ADOPT AN OAK TREE

Your donation will help save a landscape created by Saxon settlers in Transylvania 800 years ago but threatened by neglect in recent times.

The MET is now charged with managing the Breite reserve for the next five years. With your support, we can hire rangers to prevent illegal fires and motorbike races, un-checked grazing, fly-tipping, poaching and – worst of all – the cutting down of ancient trees.

By adopting an oak, you would not only save that particular tree, but also contribute to protecting the hundreds of rare species of plants, birds and animals that live in the forest.

The trees stand on a hill plateau overlooking the beautiful medieval citadel of Sighisoara, a UNESCO World Heritage site. There are more than 450 oaks, of which 163 are over 500 years old, 278 between 100 and 500 years old and 21 under 100 years old.



PLEASE HELP SAVE THIS MAGICAL WOODLAND

You can opt for one of the following three categories of Adoption:

- **GOLD £250 – adopt a tree over 500 years old.**
- **SILVER £100 – adopt a tree between 100 and 500 years old.**
- **BRONZE £50 – adopt a young tree and help it reach a ripe old age.**

In return for your donation, you will receive:

- **a certificate with a photograph of your adopted tree.**
- **e-mail updates on the state of your tree and the reserve.**
- **assistance to visit Sighisoara to see your tree (the MET runs a network of guesthouses nearby).**

breite

For more information, visit our website www.mihaieminescutrust.org or contact the MET on 020 72297618.
You could also email us on lholban@mihaieminescutrust.org